

Syllabus

Exposition: Informational Writing and Public Speaking

In this course, 7th through 9th graders will learn the ins and outs of effective expository writing and speaking in multiple real-world contexts. They will learn how to find, understand, and present information to make their ideas understood by others, building an outstanding foundation for academic and professional writing. Along the way, they'll investigate and report on events within their own homes or neighborhoods, craft a personal essay, create an original historical documentary, and learn how to communicate scientific research findings in clear, concise language. Each unit will also include a focus on a different genre of public speaking, developing oratory skills and practice.

The goal of AoPS Academy Language Arts courses is to train the intellectual leaders of the next generation by fostering creative problem solving. In our classes, students tackle projects that are framed as interpretation and communication problems: how can we communicate an idea in just the right way? Or, how can we understand complex ideas that are being communicated to us? To solve these problems, students must craft written pieces and oral presentations that demonstrate mastery of the Language Arts skills they learned in class. In this way, our courses help students develop the confidence and advanced literacy skills they need to solve any communication problem they encounter, whether it's in college, in the professional world, or in their own lives.

Time Commitment: This 36-week course includes 105 minutes of in-class instruction and 60-90 minutes of homework each week, corresponding to a full-year course.

Homework: Students should expect to spend about 1–2 hours on homework every week. Homework will include practicing the reading, writing, and grammar skills covered in class, working on ongoing writing projects, and completing reading assignments. Students are expected to read independently throughout the year from assigned novels and nonfiction books. Students will take weekly reading quizzes on the course homepage to ensure that they are keeping up with the reading.

Content:

Week	Topic	Week	Topic
1	Course Introduction	19	Why History: Unit Introduction
2	How to Build a News Article	20	Wikipedia: Use Responsibly
3	Interviewing Witnesses	21	The Hummingbird Effect
4	Gathering and Analyzing Evidence	22	The Butterfly Effect
5	Investigative Article Writing	23	Structuring a Documentary
6	Sentence and Oratorical Cadence	24	Elegant Citations
7	Clauses and Extemporizing	25	What Even Is a Rhetorical Question?
8	Peer Review and Revisions	26	Peer Review and Revisions
9	The AoPS Nightly News	27	The AoPS Documentary Film Festival
10	Your Origin Story: Unit Introduction	28	Writing Like a Scientist: Unit Introduction
11	Complicating our Stories	29	Communicating Your Context
12	Anecdotes	30	Articulating Your Approach
13	Motif	31	Reporting Your Results
14	Structuring the Personal Essay	32	Planning Your Publication
15	Time Traveling with Verb Tenses	33	The Features of Formality
16	Unleashing the Power of Passive Voice	34	Informality without Impertinence
17	Peer Review and Revisions	35	Peer Review and Revisions
18	Open Mic Night	36	The Colloquium of Discovery

The course is divided into four project-based units:

Unit	Description	Common Core Standards	Core Skills or Concepts
1 Investigative Journalism	Students dig into a real story from their own lives. Students gather and organize facts, conduct interviews, and synthesize the information into a magazine-quality investigative article. Book: <i>Global Investigative Journalism Casebook</i>	RI: 7.1, 7.5, 7.6, 7.9, 7.10, 8.1, 8.5, 8.6, 8.9, 8.10 W 7.2, 7.2.A-C, 7.3, 7.3.C, 7.4, 7.5, 7.6, 7.7, 7.10, 8.2, 8.2.A-C SL 7.1, 7.1.A-B, 7.2, 7.4, 7.6, 8.1, 8.1.A-B, 8.2, 8.4, 8.6 L 7.1, 7.2, 7.2.A, 7.2.C, 7.3, 7.6, 8.1, 8.1.D, 8.2, 8.2.A	Synthesize cohesive narrative out of multiple and contradictory sources; craft insightful interview questions and learn interview techniques; develop research plans; deploy advanced structuring techniques to improve impact.
2 Personal Essay	Students practice introspection and metacognition as they articulate, defend, and explain a belief they hold. Students will draft a personal essay that explores the experiences that have led them to forming their belief. Book: <i>Breakfast on Mars</i>	RI 7.1, 7.2, 7.3, 7.4, 7.6, 7.8, 8.10, 9-10.1, 9-10.2, 9-10.3, 9-10.4 W 7.2.F, 7.3, 8.2.B-C, 8.2.F, 8.3, 8.3.A-E, 8.4, 8.5, 8.6, 8.10, 9-10.2 SL 7.1, 7.1.A-B, 7.2, 7.6, 8.1, 9-10.1.A-B, 9-10.2, 9-10.6 L 7.2, 7.2.A, 7.2.C, 7.3, 8.3, 8.3.A, 8.6, 9-10.1, 9-10.1.B	Analyze the structure of vignettes and anecdotes; identify and deploy motif and symbolism; outlining and essay structure; presentation and vocal techniques; verb tense and perfect constructions to convey sequence of events; passive versus active voice; peer review and feedback.
3 Documentary	Students trace the historical development of an aspect of the modern world. Students create a documentary detailing the historical patterns they've uncovered, crafting a single cohesive narrative out of disparate data. Book: <i>How We Got to Now</i>	RI 7.3, 7.7, 8.7, 8.8, 9-10.2, 9-10.3, 9-10.7, 9-10.8, 9-10.10 W 7.2, 7.2.A-D, 7.3, 7.3.C, 7.4, 7.5, 8.4, 8.5, 8.6, 8.7, 8.8, 8.9, 9-10.2, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.6 SL 7.1.A-B, 7.2, 7.4, 7.5, 8.6, 9-10.2, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.6 L 7.1, 7.2, 7.2.A, 7.3, 8.3.A, 8.6, 9-10.2, 9-10.2.C, 9-10.3, 9-10.6	Research techniques and best practices; historiography; interpreting second-order events; analyzing documentary strategies; transitional phrases; rhetorical questions; strategies for multimedia presentations.
4 Scientific Writing and Presentation	Students master skills crucial to clear scientific communication: guiding an investigation and articulating complex and abstract concepts. Students investigate a scientific question and derive their own conclusion. Book: <i>What If</i>	RI 7.1, 7.2, 7.8, 7.10, 8.1, 9-10.5, 9-10.6, 9-10.7, 9-10.8, 9-10.10 W 7.1, 7.1.B-E, 7.2, 7.5, 7.6, 7.7, 8.4, 8.10, 9-10.1, 9-10.1.D-E, 9-10.2 SL 7.1, 7.1.A-B, 7.2, 7.4, 7.5, 7.6, 8.1, 9-10.2, 9-10.4, 9-10.5, 9-10.6 L 7.3, 7.3.A, 8.6, 9-10.1, 9-10.1.B, 9-10.2, 9-10.3, 9-10.6	Writing impactful conclusions and engaging introductions; strategies for framing an argument; effectively conveying results from an experiment; strategies for reading deeply and analytically; presentation design; deploying formal and informal tones in writing; providing feedback.

To interpret the Common Core Standards column on the table above, visit the Common Core ELA website at www.corestandards.org/ELA-Literacy.